

Pesticide-Free Now: A 2025 Call to Action for Urban Areas

- Urban pesticides poses significant environmental and health problems and there is no existing satisfactory measure to deal with it.
- This campaign led towards MPs, citizens, local councils and communities will make use of social, online, traditional and independent media, workshops, events and lobbying.
- Urgent action is required, thus we are leading a new campaign to demand a national ban on urban pesticides.
- By gathering citizens, experts, communities and NGOs together we can put pressure on the government to achieve our goals.

The Urban Pesticides Problem

Urban pesticides are used by local councils, landscaping companies and individuals to control insects, weed and rodents. Pesticides have hazardous effects on human health including cancer, diabetes, parkinson's disease and asthma. « *The statistical associations between exposure to certain pesticides and the incidence of some diseases are compelling and cannot be ignored* » (Kim, K-H. & al., 2016), causing 200.000 death worldwide per year. Pesticides poisoning can occur by ingestion, inhalation, physical contact or through the eyes. According to the pesticide collaboration network, urban pesticides are the second cause of pesticides intoxication after diet.

Urban pesticides poses a special threat to vulnerable people, such as older people, children and ill people and are used with higher concentrations than in rural areas. (Islam Md. M & al, 2020).

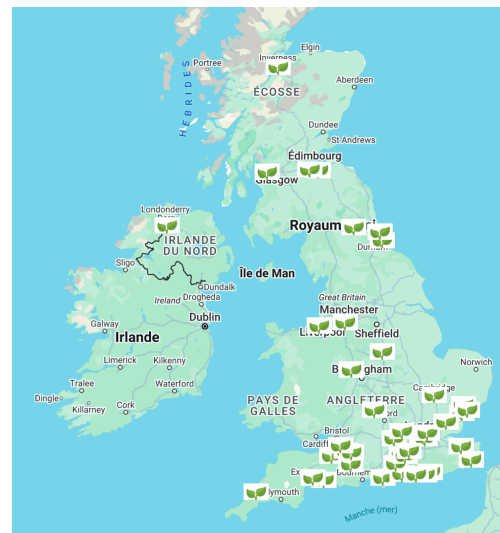
While the aesthetic and social value of pest-free (especially insects) urban environment cannot be neglected, contamination of soil, water, air and plant tissues by pesticides causes serious threats to human health and environmental pollution, such as soil degradation (Gunstone T. & al., 2021) Contamination in the urban areas is mainly of non-agricultural origin (Islam Md. M & al., 2020). Pesticides application contaminate the application site but also of the other parts of the city (volatilization, surface runoff, ground infiltration, plants contamination). It is estimated that only 0.1 % of pesticides reach their target (Pimentel D., 1995). Insufficient legislation and increase of pesticide use makes this an issue on which a campaign seems necessary.

Our goals

Despite growing scientific evidence of these harms, there is no national ban on urban pesticides in the UK (only council bans). DEFRA's inaction after their 2020 consultation¹ and the fragmented legislation on urban pesticides leave some communities exposed to

¹ <https://consult.defra.gov.uk/pesticides-future-strategy/sustainable-use-of-pesticides-national-action-plan/>

health and environmental risks. Previous campaign led by Pesticide Action Network and the Pesticide Collaboration has already contributed to increase the general public and the policy makers awareness on this issue, hence we are calling for a new bold campaign to demand a ban on private use of pesticides, a national ban on urban pesticides, and create targeted buffer areas around sensitive areas such as urban green spaces, public paths or collective facilities. However, number of campaigns on the same issue have been going previously and government did not take action. If no ban occurs we want at least to raise awareness in the general public and the decision makers to lead citizens to stop using pesticides in their backyard and make more city councils adopt a local ban on urban pesticides.



Existing local bans on urban pesticides in the UK
Source: PAN, 2024

Our approach will consist of:

- Online and IRL communication campaign through social media, online independent medias and a website created for the campaign. Get into traditional media if our campaign become big enough to get some representative to be invited.
- Workshops for members of local gardening associations to give them the ressources to promote a pesticide free town in their community and train them in ACP (Agroecological Crop Protection)
- Workshops for city councils green spaces staff and landscaping companies to train them with alternative methods: thermal weed control, preventive weed barriers, drainage improvement
- Creation of open access ressources to educate the audience on pesticides dangers and alternative methods
- Open letter model for citizens to send to their PM
- Organizing a festival celebrating pesticides-free gardening and have a stand at other relevant festivals
- MP lobbying
- Use renowned scientists as figure communicators for our campaign: Dr Rosemary Mason, Pr Dave Goulson and Dr Emily O'Brien

We are a coalition constituted of different ENGOs (Friends of the earth, Greenpeace uk, the wildlife trust, Buglife, The Soil Association, Client Earth RSPB), Health NGOs (Alliance for cancer prevention...) already existing pesticide non-state networks (Pesticide Action Network, The Pesticide Collaboration), and stakeholders to lobby MPs and give them expertise and help with policy-making to create these new policies.

Political obstacles

Our campaign will encounter obstacles, such as public misperception or vested interests. We need to understand these obstacles to develop effective strategies to overcome them.

Pesticide Industry lobbying

Through the past, the pesticide industry have proven its capacity to lobby our politicians. As there is low regulatory pressure, they may argue that there is more cost (more pest,

business troubles) than benefits. The goal of this campaign is thus also to increase the general awareness about urban pesticides to increase the regulatory pressure. Pesticide Industry actors will likely employ those strategies:

- Funding pseudo-independent studies that downplay the risk of pesticides or exaggerate the cost of a ban. This strategy has been used for neonics.²
- Direct lobbying of the MPs through meetings, a tactic used at the EU Commission.³
- Hedging (support weaker regulations or commit to reduce pesticide use) to avoid a full ban if the regulatory pressure increases.

Audience concerns about cost and effectiveness, lack of public awareness and acceptance

There may be some concerns about the effectiveness of alternatives to pesticides and the cost (training/more intensive labour) for landscaping companies, city councils and property owners in general. The general public can lack knowledge about the danger of pesticides, which can lead to apathy or even opposition to our campaign. It can also represent a constraint on government, as they will likely not take action if they know that most of the citizens oppose the project.

Governmental constraints

The government may prioritize other issues related to the UK's current situation (military, health, economy, immigration) over ecological measures. The policy makers could think a ban on urban pesticides is not a very powerful policy to get the citizens' approval. It could even lead to political polarization and to the government being highly criticized by a part of the population if it comes as a package with other environmental measures. Government departments and agencies may also have limited resources (lack of fundings, staff or expertise) to implement a ban.

Dealing with those political obstacles will require us to address to the citizens as well as to the government representatives. We need to take care of the actors' opinions about the goal of our campaign and make it get along with the economy instead of being viewed as « another disconnected environmental policy which is going to cost and make us work more ».

Dealing With Political obstacles

Our goals are to raise awareness about pesticides and knowledge about alternatives among citizens and local communities to get them to stop using pesticides and finally to get local but above all national government to take action.

To overcome obstacles that led previous campaign to not reach their goals, our coalition has to work with a variety of ENGOs, Health NGOS, city councils who banned pesticides,

² <https://unearthed.greenpeace.org/2017/11/10/neonicotinoids-bees-bayer-syngenta-michael-gove/>

³ <https://www.pan-europe.info/press-releases/2023/12/eu-commission-hosts-secret-3-day-meeting-pesticide-industry-their-exclusive>

local gardening associations and citizens. This will allow us to put more regulatory pressure on the government and be endorsed with scientific and popular legitimacy. With the support of both scientific data on pesticides and examples of countries which decided to quit urban pesticides⁴ (France, Belgium, Netherlands, Luxembourg), we will gain credibility. To counter critics on unfeasibility, we can also use existing pesticides free UK councils and implement a ban a pesticides in willing councils reached by this campaign.

We also need to frame the issue correctly, emphasize health risks, disproportionate impact of pesticides on marginalized communities, economic cost of environmental degradation and ecosystem services of birds, bees, bugs and a clean environment on the one hand, and on the other hand showcase the pesticides industry's attempts to hide pesticide dangers and use⁵ and their lobbying of policy makers. We need to be careful about the possible trade-offs from the industry. For instance, integrated Pest Management (IPM) relies a lot of synthetic pesticides and « *has arguably reached its limits.* » (Deguine, JP. & al, 2021).

On social media, our coalition members will communicate about the campaign. We will also approach influencers to reach a wider audience. We will get in touch with alternative medias keen on environmental and social issues. We will launch a website and create a series of videos presenting our campaign, the events we organize, street interviews. If possible, we will get on traditional media to reach a wider, often older and less informed about environmental issues audience.

Another big part of our actions is MP lobbying. We will brief sympathetic MPs (such as Green Party MPs) with concise material. Our communicators or NGOs could also be heard by governmental committees and will act as key figures to transmit our message.

Building on the strength of our coalition, our campaign is ready to take the next step to lead to a national awareness about urban pesticides dangers and how to deal with it and to achieve previous environmental campaign final goal: a national ban on urban pesticides and private use of pesticides.

Bibliography

- Islam Md M., Kadiyala V., Rajarathnam D., Prasath A., Mallavarapu M. (2020) Pesticides in the urban environment: A potential threat that knocks at the door, *Science of The Total Environment*, Volume 711
- Kim, Ki-Hyun; Kabir, Ehsanul; Jahan, Shamin Ara . (2016). Exposure to pesticides and the associated human health effects. *Science of The Total Environment*
- Gunstone T, Cornelisse T, Klein K, Dubey A and Donley N (2021) Pesticides and Soil Invertebrates: A Hazard Assessment. *Front. Environ.*
- Pimentel, David. (1995). Amounts of pesticides reaching target pests: Environmental impacts and ethics, *J Agric Environ Ethics* **8**, 17–29
- Deguine, JP., Aubertot, JN., Flor, R.J. & al. (2021) Integrated pest management: good intentions, hard realities. A review. *Agron. Sustain. Dev.* **41**, 38

Thomas GELGON

⁴ <https://www.pan-europe.info/campaigns/pesticide-free-towns>

⁵ https://issuu.com/pan-uk/docs/the_hidden_rise_of_uk_pesticide_use